with his persona. "Now that the film has done well, it will live on," says Anand. "Raj and Rahul have taken a backseat; he is Pathaan for everybody now." Raj is the character Shah Rukh plays in *Dilwale Dulhaniya Le Jayenge* and Rahul the one he essays in *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai*, respectively.

BEATING THE BOYCOTT CULTURE

For some, *Pathaan*'s success is vindication that hashtag boycott culture has little impact on a film's fate at the box office. It is also proof that audiences missed Khan on the big screen, with an army of his fans choosing to watch the film on the first day and multiple times. "Every minute he was on screen was an 'Ooh' moment," says filmmaker Gauri Shinde, who worked with him in *Dear Zindagi*. "We all wanted him to do well. There was so much emotion in the cinema. It felt like the old days of community viewing were back. That kind of loyalty and love is rare to find."

Pathaan also demonstrates, for the time being at least, that the Khans are here to stay, despite the doubts swirling around the Khan triumvirate's dominance in recent times, especially after Aamir-starrer *Laal Singh Chaddha* tanked. Nothing captures it better than the standout post credits scene, where SRK's Pathaan tells Salman Khan's Tiger that after three decades of duty he is debating if it's time to hang his boots. Wondering who'd take over the mantle, Pathaan concludes tongue-in-cheek, but making his point: "*Humein hi karna padega, bhai. Desh ka sawaal hai, bachchon pe nahin chhod sakte* (We will only have to do it. You can't leave the nation in the hands of kids)."

"The next generation [of actors] doesn't have that kind of sway," says a film professional who has worked with all three Khans. "The Khans aren't going anywhere. How many actors can register massive openings? How many [actors] have films in the Rs 300 crore club?" Filmmaker and author Nasreen Munni Kabir, who interviewed and followed Khan in 2004-5 for the BBC documentary *The Inner & Outer World of Shah Rukh Khan*, says, "There will never be a history book written about Indian cinema where SRK is missing. It is true of all the three Khans. They are absolutely embedded and interwoven in how Indian cinema has developed since the 1990s."

GREATEST HITS

In a career spanning 31 years and with more than 80 films to his credit, here



DILWALE DULHANIA LE JAAYENGE (1995)

Playing Raj, a London-settled desi boy who falls for Punjabi girl Simran on a Europe trip, the Aditya Chopra-directed romance marked the beginning of Khan's fandom



KUCH KUCH HOTA HAI (1998)

Sporting a "cool" chain as a collegian and later suits as a single parent, SRK wins more hearts both in India and abroad in this Karan Johar-directed love triangle about friends-turned-lovers



CHAK DE! INDIA (2007)

In what's hailed as one of Khan's finest acts, alongside *Swades* (2004), the actor plays a hockey player whose loyalty towards his nation is questioned until he coaches the women's team to glory



"Anybody who has faced so much in life has to be a strong person"

–RAJKUMAR HIRANI
Filmmaker



"Every minute he was on screen was an 'Ooh' moment"

–GAURI SHINDE
Filmmaker, on watching SRK in Pathaan